

P.S.
SAMINATHAN

40, FILM EXHIBITOR
CMD, PYRAMID SAIMIRA
TURNOVER IN 2004 Rs 2.9 crore
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 1,070 crore



FOREVER PHOENIX

first big BREAK

At 19, as an aquaculture consultant, he earned a fee of Rs 1.25 crore.

biggest LOSS

In 2004, he lost Rs 160 crore following his failed venture into CAS.

his role MODEL

Dhirubhai Ambani for his 'can do' principle. Ambani taught him to dream big.

Mention the word flop to a producer and watch him break into a cold sweat. But Panchapakasa Subramania Saminathan, chairman and managing director of Pyramid Saimira, is an exception. With an absolutely straight face and not a hint of diplomacy, he says, "*Kuselan* was an absolute disaster." The disaster in question is a Rs 30-crore extravaganza starring Tamil superstar Rajinikanth. Saminathan's calm acceptance probably stems from the fact that he has lost and made money at least half-a-dozen times in his 20-year-old career.

Though today Pyramid Saimira is the largest exhibitor of films in south India and the third largest in the world, Saminathan's early years can, at best, be described as experimental. The commerce graduate

from Loyola College, Chennai, started working when he was only 19. "I started a consultancy firm along with a few other people. We worked with aquaculture companies," he says. His first client, the Andhra Pradesh-based Aqua Prime International, paid him Rs 1.25 crore. Dazzled by the gains, Saminathan, then 20, invested heavily in his first client's company. "A day before they were going public, the Supreme Court banned coastal aquaculture. I lost Rs 15 crore," he says.

Then he cashed in on India's booming cable television market and became an operator at 21. At the peak of his cable business in 2005, just before he sold off, Saminathan's company had more than three million subscribers. In 2004, following his failed attempt at introducing digital cinema, Saminathan moved on to introduce the conditional access system (CAS) in Tamil Nadu. He set up a factory to manufacture set top boxes and just when the first batch started rolling out, it was decided that CAS would not be mandatory in the state. "I lost close to Rs 160 crore. I had to sell everything to settle the liabilities. I was completely broke," he says. Reviewing his business model, he converted the company into a theatre chain. "We transformed ourselves into a theatre exhibition company," he says. Today, Pyramid Saimira is running 875 screens in India, Malaysia, Singapore and the United States.

Seven months ago, Saminathan started distributing and producing films, though 65 per cent of his revenue still comes from exhibition. In fact, if his calculations are any indication, Pyramid Saimira may emerge as the largest exhibitor in the world this year. "Last year we sold 170 million tickets. By this year end we may reach the 240-260 million mark."

Every month the company buys six films and plans to produce 29 films by the year-end. "We are producing Chinese films. Last month, we opened the first theatre of

our proposed multiplex chain in China," says Saminathan. All this hectic activity from his Chennai office, mind you. *by Jhilmil Motihar*

SAMINATHAN FACED THE FIRST SETBACK WHEN HE WAS JUST 20. AS THE SUPREME COURT BANNED COASTAL AQUACULTURE, HE LOST RS 15 CRORE.